

McDonnell Douglas F/A-18C Hornet

The US Navy's and Marine Corps' strike aircraft since 1981, the Hornet (NASA safety support aircraft shown) has been given the unusual dual designation "F/A," as it can be used as both a fighter and an attack aircraft. Though slower than the F-14, its small size makes it extremely maneuverable. Formations of attack F/A-18s can defend themselves en-route to their target and chase enemy fighters after they have dropped their bombload.

ENGINES 2 x 16,000lb (7,257kg) thrust General Electric turbofan

WINGSPAN 36ft 6in (11.4m) **LENGTH** 56ft (17.1m)

TOP SPEED 1,190mph (1,915kph) (Mach 1.8) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 1 x 20mm Vulcan cannon; 2 x Sidewinder air-to-air missiles, up to 17,000lb (7,711kg) attack weapons (bombs or missiles)



Mikoyan-Gurevich MiG-23M "Flogger"



The MiG-23 was the first Soviet swing-wing aircraft, and its main purpose was to take on Phantoms and other Western attack aircraft. To do this, it carried more interception radar and so was bigger than its predecessor, the MiG-21. Fitting variable-geometry wings reduced the take-off and landing run, so the airplane could still use small front-line airfields in the traditional Soviet manner. MiG-23s served with the Soviet Union and its allies from 1973 until the 1990s.

ENGINE 27,512lb (12,500kg) thrust Khachaturov turbojet

WINGSPAN 45ft 9in (14m) **LENGTH** 51ft 7in (15.7m)

TOP SPEED 1,546mph (2,490kph) (Mach 2.35) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 1 x 23mm twin-barrel cannon; 10 x air-to-air missiles

Mikoyan-Gurevich MiG-25P "Foxbat"

The MiG-25 was developed in response to the American Lockheed A-11 (which became the SR-71). The prototype flew in 1964, and although by then the American airplane was only a reconnaissance project, development of the Russian interceptor continued. In limited service, it is the world's fastest combat fighter.



ENGINES 2 x 24,651lb (11,200kg) thrust Tumanskii turbojet

WINGSPAN 45ft 11in (14m) **LENGTH** 64ft 9in (19.8m)

TOP SPEED 1,868mph (3,000kph) (Mach 2.83) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 4 x AA-6 air-to-air missiles

Mikoyan-Gurevich MiG-29 "Fulcrum"

The MiG-29, with the now familiar layout of twin tails with twin underslung engines, uses the fuselage between the engines as part of the lift area, giving it amazing maneuverability. Like the Su-27, it was designed to counter the newest American aircraft – F-15, F-16, and F-18. In service since 1984, the MiG demonstrated its abilities by performing "tail-slides" at air shows during the 1990s – something no Western aircraft could do.



ENGINES 2 x 18,268lb (8,300kg) thrust Klimov RD-33 turbofan

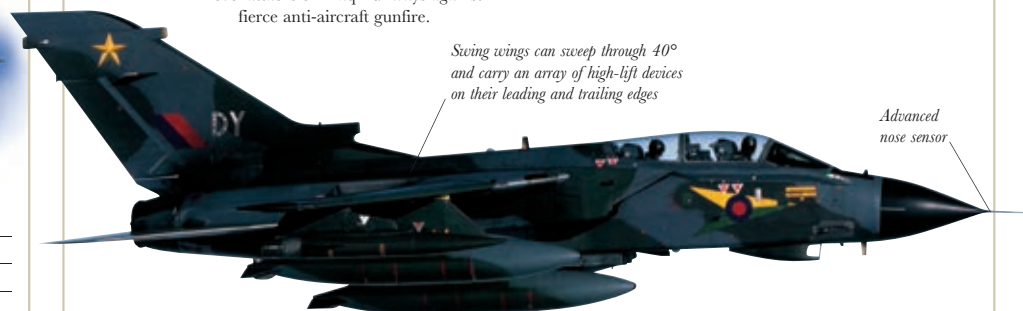
WINGSPAN 37ft 3in (11.4m) **LENGTH** 56ft 10in (17.3m)

TOP SPEED 1,521mph (2,450kph) (Mach 2.3) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 1 x 30mm cannon; 6 x AA-10 air-to-air missiles

Panavia Tornado GR 1

The first European multi-role combat aircraft, the Tornado was designed and built by a consortium of British, German, and Italian aircraft manufacturing companies. In service with the air forces of these three countries since 1980, the Tornado uses a variable geometry or swing-wing to give good maneuverability and supersonic attack capability. RAF Tornados undertook the most dangerous missions of the 1991 Gulf War – low-level attacks on Iraqi runways against fierce anti-aircraft gunfire.



ENGINES 2 x 15,800lb (7,178kg) thrust Turbo Union turbofan

WINGSPAN 45ft 8in (13.9m) **LENGTH** 54ft 9in (16.7m)

TOP SPEED 1,452mph (2,336kph) (Mach 2.2) **CREW** 2

ARMAMENT 2 x 27mm IWKa-Mauser cannon; up to 18,000 lb (8,172 kg) of ordnance, including free fall or guided bombs, unguided rockets, JP 233 runway-cratering weapons, Sidewinder air-to-air missiles, air-to-ground missiles, and electronic warfare pods

Saab 39 Gripen

Using the same delta wing with canard (a second wing fitted near the nose) layout as its Viggen predecessor, the Gripen is significantly smaller yet performs even better. It can also operate as an interceptor, ground-attack, or sea-attack aircraft, simply by fitting different armaments and selecting the appropriate mission characteristics from the advanced computer system. Design began in 1982 but the aircraft was not declared operational until 1997. As well as being used by the Swedish Air Force, it has been bought by Hungary, the Czech Republic, and South Africa, and serves as a jet trainer with Britain's Empire Test Pilots' School. There are both single- and dual-seat versions.



ENGINE 18,500lb (8,223kg) thrust Volvo RM12 turbofan

WINGSPAN 27ft 6in (8.4m) **LENGTH** 46ft 3in (14.1m)

TOP SPEED 1,320mph (2,124kph) (Mach 2) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 1 x 27mm Mauser cannon; 2 x Sidewinder air-to-air missiles, plus up to 8 x air-to-air missiles, air-to-ground, or anti-ship, or cruise missiles, or bomb dispenser

Sukhoi Su-27 "Flanker"

While the Sukhoi is considerably larger than the MiG, this, surprisingly, does not compromise agility, but allows instead a smoother blending of wing and fuselage lift areas. The aircraft entered service with the Soviet (now Russian) Air Force in 1986. The Su-27 also forms the core of China's People's Liberation Army Air Force.



ENGINES 2 x 27,588lb (12,533kg) thrust Saturn/Lyul'ka turbofan

WINGSPAN 48ft 2in (14.7m) **LENGTH** 71ft 11in (21.94m)

TOP SPEED 1,550mph (2,495kph) (Mach 2.35) **CREW** 1

ARMAMENT 1 x 30mm cannon; 10 x AA-10 air-to-air missiles